Assessments

MATH 107: Introduction to Linear Algebra — Fall 2026

Labs

Lab points (effort) are earned in class: work the hub exercises in Octave or Python, handwrite answers on the one-pager hard copy, and get check-in initials after a short conversation. Exercises are on each lab page in both languages; the one-pager is linked from the hub so you can preview it. Quizzes may ask about lab ideas. See Lab 0 for the pattern.

Lab	Date	Learning objectives
Lab 0: Computers Speak Vectors	Fri Aug 28	Enter, index, and modify vectors in Octave or Python; plot and debug supplied code.
Lab 1: Finding Similar Things	Fri Oct 16	Compute distances; name a nearest neighbor; see the effect of a bad feature scale.
Lab 2: Gaussian elimination	Fri Oct 23	Eliminate with elementary matrices; back-substitute by hand; solve and check $Ax = b$ in Octave or Python.
Lab 3: Nutrients, cost, LU	Fri Oct 30	Same nutrient matrix, two meal targets; count ops; package elimination as LU; peek at $[A \mid I]$; power syntax.
Lab 4: Inverses, Rank, and Determinants	Fri Nov 6	Compute inverses in software; singular failure; rank–nullity; interpret determinants.
Lab 5: Long-Run Mix and Eigen	Fri Nov 20	Discover a shared long-run campus mix by iteration; explain it with $\lambda = 1$ / $\lvert\lambda\rvert < 1$.
Lab 6: Fit and Compress	Fri Dec 4	Least-squares fit; truncated SVD; residual and storage $k(m + n + 1)$ — same-day warm-up with the SVD lecture / **project launch**.

Labs 1–6 (and quizzes) meet on **Fridays**. There is no lab on Midterm 2 day or during fall break. Friday Dec 4 is titled **project launch** (capstone packet); Lab 6 is the LS + SVD warm-up that same day.

Quizzes

Eleven quizzes. Quiz 7 (Fri Oct 23) is online in Canvas. The others are in the first 10 minutes of class. The lowest two scores are dropped. Practice packets are grouped as **Core** and **Stretch**. Each Friday quiz covers **only the prior instructional week** (not that day's new lecture or lab).

A consistent quiz has three parts:

- **Fluency** (4–5 points): one small calculation closely modeled on a practice item.
- **Meaning** (3–4 points): explain or interpret what the calculation says.
- **Computation/application** (2–3 points): interpret code, a plot, a residual, or software output.

You will not write substantial code from scratch on a timed quiz. Typical prompts: complete one missing line, predict three lines of output, identify an error, interpret output, or choose an appropriate command.

Every second or third quiz includes a short cumulative item from an earlier packet (beginning with Quiz 3).

Source key

Code	Source
B 3.10	Boyd and Vandenberghe, Exercise 3.10
S 6.1 #10	Strang, Section 6.1, Problem 10
L Ch. 2 Ex. 3	Lachniet, *Introduction to GNU Octave* (3rd ed., 2020), Chapter 2, Exercise 3
C	Course-created bridge or lab checkpoint

A "prompt" can be one selected part of a multi-part textbook exercise.

CLO coverage

Official course learning outcomes are assessed more than once; nothing important is a single-day checklist item.

Required outcome	Where it is developed and assessed
Interpret vectors, matrices, and complex numbers algebraically and geometrically	Weeks 1–3, 7, and 13
Solve systems by row reduction by hand and with software	Lectures 21–22 and Lab 2; Midterm 2; cumulative final
Find 2×2 eigenpairs by hand and general eigenpairs with software	November 18 and Lab 5
Apply eigenvalues and eigenvectors	Dynamics in Week 9, explained in Week 13; Markov/normal-mode applications
Recognize triangular, symmetric, and positive-definite matrices	October 5, November 6, and December 2
Use linear combination, subspace, span, independence, basis, and dimension	Weeks 1 and 5, revisited in Weeks 8 and 11

Required outcome	Where it is developed and assessed
Write or adapt programs involving matrices, vectors, and plotting	Labs 0–6 and the capstone, with steadily reduced scaffolding
Apply linear algebra to real-world problems	Every lab and most class examples
Learn independently and collaboratively	Practice banks, low-stakes quizzes, paired work, lab studio, and capstone presentation
ILO/GEAR quantitative reasoning in context	Interpretation questions throughout; least-squares and capstone conclusions

Quiz dates

Friday quizzes cover **only the prior instructional week** (skip midterm week and fall break when choosing that week). Same-day lecture/lab topics are not on that day's quiz.

Quiz	Date	Focus (prior week)
Quiz 1	Fri Sep 4	Vectors, arithmetic, Lab 0 (Week 1)
Quiz 2	Fri Sep 11	Combinations, inner product, linear functions (Week 2)
Quiz 3	Fri Sep 18	Applications and norms (Week 3)
Quiz 4	Fri Sep 25	Angle, nearest neighbors, and clustering (Week 4)
Quiz 5	Fri Oct 9	Dependence, span, and basis (Week 5)
Quiz 6	Fri Oct 16	Matrices and Ax (Week 7 / Lectures 18–19)
Quiz 7	Fri Oct 23	Transforms only (Lecture 20). Online in Canvas.
Quiz 8	Fri Oct 30	Systems, elimination, RREF, dynamics, and iteration (Lectures 21–23)
Quiz 9	Fri Nov 6	RREF and one-step dynamics (Lecture 22)
Quiz 10	Fri Nov 20	Inverses, rank, and determinants (Lectures 27–29)
Quiz 11	Fri Dec 4	Eigenvalues, complex numbers, and Lab 5 (Week 13 / Lectures 35–37)

Not on a dedicated quiz (assessed on Midterm 2, the final, and/or the capstone): same-day lecture/lab topics on quiz Fridays; Week 15 least squares / SVD. Use the Midterm 2 practice packet, final practice packet, and capstone packet as appropriate.

Exams

In-class, for the entire class period.

Exam	Date	Learning objectives
Midterm 1 (in class; not posted)	Fri Oct 2	Compute with vectors and linear functions; interpret operations; analyze distance, similarity, span, and independence; select and communicate a method. Day page: Lecture 16. Prep: study guide, practice.
Midterm 2 (in class; not posted)	Fri Nov 13	Analyze matrices as transformations and models; solve and interpret systems; use products, powers, rank, inverses, and determinants; interpret results in context. Day page: Lecture 27. Prep: study guide, practice. Covers Lectures 18–25 (hand math; no software).
Final exam	Wed Dec 16, 10:20 a.m.–12:10 p.m., FR 201	Hand fluency; select tools in new contexts; interpret software; explain connections among major concepts; apply linear algebra to quantitative problems. Prep: study guide, practice.

Project

Project	Dates	Learning objectives
Capstone	Dec 4 launch, Dec 7 studio, Dec 9 gallery	Low-rank SVD strategy; compare reconstruction error, storage, and runtime; present quantitative evidence and limitations.

Class participation

Attendance and participation in class.